Arkade

CONCEPT PAPER

NW Arkansas Global Retail & Supply Chain Innovation Initiative

A public-private partnership initiative by the Greater Bentonville Area Chamber of Commerce and Arkade to build structured commercialization infrastructure for global retail technology companies seeking entry into Northwest Arkansas.

Partners: Greater Bentonville Chamber of Commerce & Spring Arkade LLC dba Arkade

Date: March 2026 | Draft Working Document

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Structured infrastructure to convert global interest into regional impact.

Northwest Arkansas is one of the most influential retail ecosystems in the world, anchored by global headquarters for Walmart, Sam's Club, JB Hunt Transport, Tyson Foods and more than 1,100 supplier offices. While the region continues to grow in economic strength and national visibility, it lacks structured infrastructure to intentionally convert global retail and supply chain technology interest into measurable regional economic impact.

Out-of-market (primarily international) growth-stage B2B technology companies want access to Bentonville's decision-makers. However, without a formalized landing pathway, curated commercialization support, and coordinated economic development infrastructure, interest does not consistently translate into:

- Physical relocation and expansion
- High-skill job creation
- Pilot conversion and innovation adoption by enterprises
- Long-term capital investment in the region

The Greater Bentonville Chamber of Commerce, in partnership with Arkade, proposes a **three-year initiative** to build structured commercialization opportunities and soft-landing infrastructure for global retail value chain technology companies seeking entry into Northwest Arkansas.

The initiative will be administered by the Chamber as fiduciary partner and delivered in collaboration with Arkade's commercial growth platform. Together, the partners will activate greenfield opportunities through public-private collaboration, de-risking market entry for global firms, and drive measurable economic impact for the region.

> We are seeking **catalytic grant funding over a three-year period.** The specific investment amount is under development and will be finalized in collaboration with all partners.

GRANT FUNDING WILL SUPPORT FIVE KEY COMPONENTS:

- **Market Intelligence** and Strategic Positioning
- **Global Recruitment** and Market-Entry Pipeline
- **Commercialization** and Market Activation Platform
- **Embedding and Expansion** Support
- **Talent and Ecosystem** Integration

THE CHALLENGE

Opportunity without infrastructure.

Northwest Arkansas offers a rare concentration of global retail and supply chain leadership, major CPG presence, a sophisticated talent pool, rapid population growth, and supportive economic development leadership. However, the region competes globally for innovation companies that often default to coastal U.S. cities or other international hubs.

At the same time, international B2B retail and supply chain technology companies face significant barriers when entering U.S. enterprise markets, including limited access to decision-makers, regulatory and operational complexity, lack of trusted local networks, high cost of entry, and cultural and commercial differences.

TODAY, WITHOUT STRUCTURED INFRASTRUCTURE:

- International companies conduct cold outreach for virtual calls or visit Bentonville for 1–2 days of meetings
- Introductions are made informally
- Most companies leave without establishing a sustained presence
- There is no formalized soft-landing program connecting companies to workspace, pilot pathways, regulatory navigation, workforce, and economic development support

> Without a formal commercialization platform, Northwest Arkansas risks losing high-growth companies to more coordinated ecosystems such as **Austin, Atlanta, New York, and Toronto.**

The intent is to bridge market-entry barriers with a structured soft landing zone — positioning Northwest Arkansas as the primary U.S. gateway for retail technology and supply chain innovation.

THE SOLUTION

A structured global retail commercialization platform.

The partnership will launch a structured public-private commercialization platform to attract, embed, and scale high-growth B2B retail and supply chain technology companies — transforming global innovation interest into sustained economic impact for Northwest Arkansas.

The **Global Retail Commercialization Program** will operate as an annual cohort-based initiative supporting 6–12 growth-stage retail technology and supply chain companies through a structured six-month market entry and commercialization engagement. Participating companies will receive dedicated guidance, curated introductions to retailers, suppliers, investors, and ecosystem leaders, and access to physical workspace at Arkade.

TARGET COMPANY PROFILE

- Native to an international (primary) or non-local U.S. (secondary) market
- Commerce-enabling technology: retail, supply chain, AI/data, automation, sustainability
- Series A+ with demonstrated product-market fit, revenue generating or late-stage pilot
- Actively seeking U.S. market entrance or expansion
- Capable of hiring locally within 12 months

PROGRAM ARCHITECTURE

Five pillars. One structured pathway.

01

Market Intelligence & Strategic Positioning

THE FOUNDATION LAYER

Identify the right companies and position NWA competitively in global recruitment markets.

GRANT-SUPPORTED ACTIVITIES

- Research tools (Harmonic, CRM, data subscriptions)
- Sector mapping and global company identification
- Investor mapping
- Competitive landscape analysis
- Impact dashboarding

02

Global Recruitment & Market-Entry Pipeline

THE ACQUISITION LAYER

Proactively source and attract qualified companies through roadshows, embassy partnerships, and targeted outreach.

GRANT-SUPPORTED ACTIVITIES

- Dedicated recruitment/ecosystem growth lead
- International roadshows and recruitment events
- Embassy and trade partnerships
- Inbound innovation summits
- Targeted outreach campaigns

03

Commercialization & Market Activation Platform

THE CONVERSION LAYER

Convert visiting companies into active commercial participants through a soft-landing commercialization program. Annual cohort of 6–12 growth-stage companies through a 6-month structured engagement.

GRANT-SUPPORTED ACTIVITIES

- **Bentonville Market Immersion Week** — 2–4 day welcome visit with 5+ warm intro meetings, campus tours, and cultural orientation
- **Visa and relocation navigation** for each company
- **Industry education workshops** (monthly) — curated 10-person lunches on demand-driven retail topics
- **BiteSized Conference** (quarterly) — closed-door discussions between founders, retail executives, and investors
- **Bi-Annual NWA Tech Summit** — high-visibility convening with global founder showcases, supplier panels, and talent programming
- Curated introductions to customers, partners, and talent throughout program
- Pilot facilitation and implementation support

04

Embedding & Expansion Support

THE RETENTION LAYER

Transforming initial visits into sustained presence, helping companies build enduring operations and meaningful local impact.

GRANT-SUPPORTED ACTIVITIES

- Legal and regulatory navigation
- Entity formation support
- Visa guidance
- Workspace access
- Investor introductions
- Community integration
- Relocation support
- Local media content creation and engagement

05

Talent & Ecosystem Integration

THE COMPOUNDING LAYER

Create two-way integration between incoming companies and the regional workforce — strengthening stickiness and long-term retention.

GRANT-SUPPORTED ACTIVITIES

- **Retail Innovation Fellows** — paid internships within Arkade member companies
- Career pathway development with University of Arkansas and regional institutions
- Embedding in local industry panels, workshops, and meetups with external groups
- Advisor/Mentor workshops
- Talent network outreach and recommendation

MEASURABLE OUTCOMES (OVER 3 YEARS)

Clear targets. Accountable results.

Pillar 1: Market Intelligence & Positioning

500+ qualified global companies identified and segmented in recruitment database	**150+** high-priority targets actively tracked through data-informed outreach
50+ corporate relocation or expansion leads generated	**10+** sector intelligence reports produced, plus comprehensive economic impact dashboard

Pillar 2: Recruitment & Market Entry

60+ companies visiting NWA for exploratory meetings, immersion, or summits	**25+** formal partnerships with international trade orgs, embassies, and innovation networks

Pillar 3: Commercialization Platform

20–30 growth-stage companies supported through structured commercialization programming	**75+** curated enterprise introductions with documented follow-on engagement
15+ retailer or supplier pilot programs launched	**$10M+** in venture or growth capital attracted by participating companies

Pillar 4: Embedding & Expansion

10+ companies establishing a formal operating presence in NWA	**30+** high-skill jobs offered in Northwest Arkansas
70%+ retention rate — companies maintaining regional engagement 24 months post-program	**$5M+** cumulative local revenue from embedded companies

Pillar 5: Ecosystem & Talent Integration

15 Retail Innovation Fellows placed within participating or Arkade-affiliated companies	**100+** curated mentor, advisor, or executive engagements facilitated

GOVERNANCE & STRUCTURE

Accountability, transparency, and alignment.

CHAMBER LEADS ON

- Grant applications and compliance
- Regional economic development alignment
- Civic and corporate introductions
- Marketing and visibility
- Relocation assistance
- Economic impact metrics monitoring

ARKADE LEADS ON

- Execute recruitment strategy
- Deliver programming and support services
- Manage company relationships
- Track commercialization outcomes
- Coordinate ecosystem engagement

On governance: All grant funds administered through the Chamber. Funds allocated strictly toward approved programmatic activities. Clear KPIs and quarterly reporting. Annual public economic impact reporting produced.

BUDGET OVERVIEW

Investment categories defined. Amounts under development.

Grant Request	Partner Contributions
TBD	TBD

Personnel

- Head of Global Retail Innovation Growth
- Member Education & Programming Manager
- Director of Portfolio Operations (partial allocation)
- Contracted event coordination

Program Infrastructure

- Workspace allocation (pro-rated facility use)
- Software tools (Harmonic AI, CRM systems)
- Marketing support (pro-rated contract)

Events & Convening

- Quarterly mini-conference (BiteSized)
- Monthly ecosystem programming
- Bi-annual NWA Tech Summit

Travel & Recruitment

- International recruitment travel
- Key domestic industry events
- Inbound summit travel

Administration

- 10–15% program administration
- Fiscal oversight through Chamber

COST SHARE & SUSTAINABILITY

Catalytic funding with a clear path toward sustainability.

The funding structure will be designed to taper over three years, transitioning toward earned revenue, corporate sponsorship, and long-term sustainability. Specific year-over-year allocations are under development.

LONG-TERM SUSTAINABILITY MECHANISMS

- Company participation fees
- Corporate sponsorship
- Event ticket revenue
- Increased Arkade membership beyond cohort
- Regional economic development support

WHY THIS MATTERS NOW

A pivotal moment for Northwest Arkansas.

Global Retail Influence	Rapid Growth	Corporate Density	National Visibility
Anchored by Walmart and its extensive supplier ecosystem	Top-20 fastest-growing U.S. metro, projected 1M+ by 2050	Concentrated decision-makers and innovation capacity	Recognized hub for retail and supply chain leadership

Competing ecosystems across the U.S. are aggressively pursuing the same innovators seeking access to Walmart and its supplier network. This initiative ensures Bentonville becomes not just a destination for meetings, but a **relocation and growth hub** for companies driving the next generation of retail innovation.

REGIONAL COMPARABLES & BENCHMARKS

A proven category. Measurable returns.

Austin, Texas

Opportunity Austin / Global Launch Pad

Backed by the Austin Chamber — structurally the most direct analog to this initiative. **400+ foreign-owned companies** now operating in the Austin region. Austin is the most direct U.S. market competitor to NWA; the fact that Austin has formalized a Chamber-backed soft-landing program while NWA has not is a competitive risk this initiative directly addresses.

Atlanta, Georgia

Georgia Tech Enterprise Innovation Institute

Since 2018, achieved a **68% U.S. expansion rate** — 15 of 22 participating international companies successfully expanded. This compares to an industry average of ~30% for informal market entry, demonstrating that structured programming is the decisive variable in conversion.

Toronto, Ontario

Toronto Global

The closest operational model at larger scale. **260 structured investments** generating **33,000+ jobs** and **$1.3B CAD in cumulative tax impact**. In 2023/24 alone, 44 investments produced 5,527 jobs. These numbers establish that structured investment attraction programs are high-return economic infrastructure.

The bottom line: Every comparable metro that has built this infrastructure has seen measurable economic returns. NWA has everything those metros have — and in the retail and supply chain sector, considerably more. What it has lacked is the infrastructure. This initiative builds it.

THE PARTNERSHIP CASE

Three organizations. Each essential. None sufficient alone.

Arkade brings the commercial engine: six months of real-world validation behind a platform built to do what no other regional entity does — convert global retail technology interest into pilots, partnerships, and sustained presence in Bentonville. Arkade does not replicate what exists. It delivers what the ecosystem has been missing.

The Greater Bentonville Area Chamber of Commerce brings the civic mandate and institutional credibility to make this work at a regional scale. Its own Bold Bentonville strategic plan explicitly names this kind of coordinated commercialization infrastructure as a priority — and names the Walton Family Foundation as a key partner in getting there.

The Walton Family Foundation brings the catalytic capital that transforms a proven concept into a regional system. The Foundation's mission — "to support innovation, new ideas and, above all, community-led change" — is precisely what this partnership structure embodies: a nonprofit leading, a commercial platform delivering, and philanthropic investment creating conditions that no single actor could produce alone.

> Together, these three partners represent the **full stack that regional economic development requires** — private-sector execution, civic accountability, and philanthropic catalysis. The initiative does not work without all three. With all three, it builds something Northwest Arkansas will benefit from for decades.

LONG-TERM VISION

The global capital of retail innovation.

Over time, the program will evolve into a self-sustaining, self-reinforcing platform supported by corporate sponsorships, membership participation, private investment partnerships, and revenue-generating services.

Within five years, Northwest Arkansas will be recognized as the global capital of retail innovation — the premier U.S. destination for retail technology and supply chain companies seeking market entry, validation, and growth. The region will become a magnet for high-growth companies, cultivate a nationally recognized commercialization ecosystem, and provide a lasting home for international firms establishing U.S. operations.

Through strong public-private collaboration, this initiative will catalyze innovation, accelerate job creation, and drive sustained economic growth, solidifying Northwest Arkansas' position as a globally competitive, innovation-driven region.